

THE ADANADI

The Adanadi is arguably more world-altering than The Awis. It touches almost every living thing in Makasing and is a key factor in the latest wave of social and technological change, bringing people enhanced abilities and newfound powers. It has changed the very fabric of daily life for human beings and completely altered the trajectories of every society. But what exactly is the Adanadi? Why was it called “The Gift”? And how did it come to be harnessed?

Most stories of the Awis, regardless of where they originate, usually involve the color purple. These stories all predate the appearance of the Adanadi. Ancient written records in the Ezcan Empire refer to the color multiple times. Stories usually call back to a purple streak that crossed the sky the night of the event. It was

bright and shimmering and big enough that the trail could still be seen well into the next dawn. In Makasing, the color purple has since become associated with the Great Spirit.

Within roughly two hundred years, reports began circulating of small purple splotches appearing on animals, plants and people. Often no larger than a few centimeters, the spots were taken as blessings from the Great Spirit by some, while others feared it was the beginnings of a blight or plague. People with the marks were sometimes considered chosen, wise, or gifted. Soon, the purple marks became ubiquitous and people began to see them as omens that the Great Spirit would return one day to heal the Earth and set things right.

Over the centuries, these purple marks began to root themselves in various ceremonies and traditions. The areas containing the discoloration were separated from the plant or animal and used in hundreds of different ways – from ointments and teas to components of mind altering drugs and as part of ceremonial paints and inks. No tribe on the planet was left untouched by the Adanadi. The name became common during the trade explosion between the Keetoowagi Republic and Abayang. Still, it has more than two hundred recognized names and thousands of nicknames throughout the world.

The real power of the Adanadi began to be understood when advances in biology and chemistry began unfolding. Discoveries through a number of nations over the course of a decade around the year 370 peeled back the first layer of mysteries behind the purple-hued marks. The marks were not cancerous or malignant in any way, yet there were similarities. The tissue was different from its surroundings in a way that some labeled as a mutation – one that coexisted harmoniously with the nearby tissue. Further study revealed that there was a massive

variety in how the Adanadi presented itself from species to species and that the Adanadi itself represented a form of life previously not seen on Earth. It had aspects similar to bacteria, eukarya, and archaea, but fell into none of those families exclusively.

How the next step was achieved is the source of debate among many. No person, tribe, or nation claims it as part of their history. It was discovered that by taking the affected tissue from an animal, distilling and purifying certain aspects of it, and injecting it into the brain stem of a human during the peak of adolescence would cause a radical and permanent change in their physiology. Doing this procedure too early or too late in life produced no results and the changes, once initiated, could not be stopped, altered, or added to. This was the beginning of Paths.

It was quickly discovered that plants could not be used in the same way as animals in this procedure. There were simply too many biological differences. But with the injection of the animal Adanadi, people changed afterward, often taking on the culturally associated traits of the animal.

CHAPTER 7

In some cases, between 15-20% by some estimates, people actually developed an ability that was outside of normal human parameters, a power. Those who took the Path of the Fox might find themselves more agile and strong of spirit, two traits associated with Fox. They might also find themselves with a special ability related to their agility or spirit. The people granted these extra gifts often go on to become important figures in their community.

A side effect of this was that as certain people grew up with Adanadi- affected intellect, perception, and wisdom, the collective speed of scientific progress across both continents skyrocketed. Medicine, agriculture, and engineering were already progressing rapidly, but the Adanadi became such a profound change that it put huge cultural pressure on people and governments.

Within decades, war broke out. This further accelerated the technological and scientific advancements happening, as war often does. Things were getting out of hand.

It was during this period of rapid change that certain trends and

procedures began to become more deeply embedded in cultures and traditions. Within a century, taking the Adanadi and choosing a Path hadn't just become widespread; it was the default. It's estimated that 99% of all people alive currently have undergone the ritual of the Adanadi.

It has become a celebration of passage into adulthood, a reason for communities to gather and rejoice. With the current peace across the continent, two full generations have been able to grow up working to develop the full potential and range of their gifts. The shape, style, and substance of these celebrations vary wildly from region to region, but they no longer involve painful injections into the brain. These days there are a number of less invasive methods; among the most popular are concentrated eye drops.

Additionally, animals are often no longer directly harvested for the Adanadi, especially for more rare species like eagles. Instead, scientists have been able to take tissue samples from an animal and culture them in a lab. Scientists can now occasionally predict what kind of abilities a person might get from various animals, but most



CHAPTER 7

people have integrated tradition into their Path choices and select from culturally significant animals rather than basing their choices on what ability they might receive.

Still, it's important to note that while science has been able to explain the what, where, and when of the Adanadi, researchers still don't understand the why or the how. They know that the unusual cells in the Adanadi activate certain latent genes in human brains and sometimes alter DNA, but not much more. The spiritual voices in the community remind their communities that the traits they receive from the animals match traditional stories about those animals.

There are new uses for the Adanadi around every corner. Yutsu technology is a prime example. Over a hundred and fifty years ago, scientists discovered that by taking Adanadi tissue and exposing it to focused electromagnetic energy, it would emit negative gravitons. This discovery led to the hover technology, called yutsu, used by most modern vehicles in the world today. It's also used in magbows, plumbing, and a number of other inventions.

The Adanadi is everywhere, in everyone. It is part of daily life for every human, animal, and plant known. But what it actually is and how it does what it does is still, at its core, a total mystery.

The Abilities of the Adanadi

Undergoing the Adanadi is generally considered a positive and happy occasion. The choice to take a particular Path is decided in a variety of ways from family to family, tribe to tribe and region to region. The normal results of that Path are predictable and safe. There is virtually no rejection rate or long term side effects.

But the Ability that one receives, if a person does indeed get one at all, isn't chosen. From what even the best scientists can tell, it's random. Those who look for more spiritual answers will tell you that it's not random at all. Either way, no one knows for sure what Ability they'll end up with.

Once they've taken the Adanadi, the full process is complete within 48 hours. The person undergoes a brief fever and overwhelming urge to sleep, but it is otherwise painless. Within a week of the process,

the person will have an intuitive feeling of whether they have an Ability, as well as an understanding of what it is and how to express it.

Roughly 15-20% of people who undergo the Adanadi receive a power. While a true census is difficult to obtain, this seems to be true in all nations and regions. The actual Abilities obtained are more of a mystery. The Abilities listed in this book are the ones that commonly present themselves in the Free Lands. But it is by no means all of them, or all that are known. What also isn't known is whether Abilities within a particular Path are more or less likely than others to manifest. In a city of 2 million people, like Cahokia, almost 400,000 people have Abilities. But with fifteen Paths and six common Abilities per Path, there are just too few people to do conclusive studies.

Nevertheless, some Abilities have affected the fabric of society more than others. They have added to the already mounting social pressures on rapidly changing cultures and governments. Inevitably, some divisions have formed between people of certain

Paths or around those who have certain Abilities.

In sports, there are debates about limiting the use of Power of the Bear, Gecko's Heart and Cougar's Grace. The level of physicality across multiple games and sporting events has inspired discussions about both fairness and safety.

Wasp's Sting has started a very real scientific debate about the nature of reality and physics as people understand it. Affecting another person across distance without a detectable energy being transferred is understandably concerning to those people who are interested in codifying the measurable nature of reality.

Abilities like Raven's Call, Stag's Smile, and Coyote's Gaze have raised serious concerns about consent, privacy, and thought control. They have inspired numerous conspiracies about shadow governments and mass mind control.

Walk the Black, Mother's Voice, and Read the Earth might be the most controversial however. These Abilities grant the users a direct line to insights and experiences often reserved for those who had participated in specific ceremonies or are of particular reli-

CHAPTER 7

gious status. Having these experiences, formerly reserved as ethereal and subjective, becoming available at will has created severe backlash among some.

This to say, having an Ability, while common enough that no one is shocked by them, is still an unsettled matter among most people. People with Abilities sometimes brag about them or show them off. Others are more cautious, wanting to gauge their audience. Many attempt to simply work their Abilities into their daily lives in such a fashion that it becomes less obvious they are using them at all. Since most Abilities don't have visual or auditory aspects, this is a real possibility for many. Those without powers have a wide variety of reactions, from mistrust or hatred to envy and admiration. There are social clubs and even cults around specific Paths and Abilities. How these perspectives change will likely be determined by how those with these Abilities choose to use them over the coming years.

It might be tempting to think of individuals using these Abilities the way superheroes do. They just reach out a hand or their eyes glow. A thought from the charac-



ter simply manifests an action. However, it's not how it plays out in reality for most people. Science and spirituality are deeply intertwined when it comes to Abilities and how people summon them depends greatly on the person's background, beliefs, and the Ability itself. If an effect is instantaneous, a person might yell out a whoop, war cry, chant, or call out an ancestor's name. They might gesture with their eyes or chin or make a signal with their hands. If it's something that takes longer than a Round, there might be chanting, singing, or dancing involved. None of these are required as a game mechanic, but it's important to remember that these Abilities are expressions and extensions of the character's Path and culture.

